

OTTI BERGER AND THE BAUHAUS: REVOLUTIONARY FIBERS



Otti Berger, *Sample for Wall Covering*, 1933, cellulose-based ribbon.

I invite you to look at this piece of fabric. Tattered sections of felted fiber. Loose, frayed edges. Threads jutting out demonstrating age and wear. There's nothing ornamental about this work. No bright color, nor pretty pattern. Nothing beautiful to ponder or admire. To the average viewer, one may not know how to approach looking at this work. So, where do we find its value?

Why this fabric? And why does the title of this essay imply that it's revolutionary? To answer this question, let's first look at the designer.

This is the work of weaver Otti Berger. Berger studied at the infamous Bauhaus school in Dessau, Germany between 1927 to 1932. The plainness of this fabric, is in fact, an indicator of Berger's radical ideas that challenged accepted notions of weaving's function as a medium. Berger, like the Bauhaus, was passionate about merging art, craft, and industry through developing designs that improved society's spaces. She created woven works of different functions: wall coverings, furniture, rugs, and wall separators using the new materials that she had experimented with within the school's Weaving Workshop. In her theoretical texts, *Stoffe im Raum* (1930) and *Stoffe und neues Bauen* (1933), Berger emphasizes the importance of experimenting with new synthetic materials and techniques in order to create more functional and intentional objects. The furniture fabrics of the time were ornate, but not well suited for their purposes. Berger's fabrics enhanced everyday experiences like sitting in a chair and lounging in a room with wall coverings that filled the space with light. Berger's passion directly aligns with the aims of the Bauhaus' leader and founder, Walter Gropius, who proclaims in the school's manifesto: "The ultimate goal of all art is the building!" What he is describing here is the belief that art and craft's primary goal should be making work that functions within spaces, not work that hangs on gallery walls.¹ Gropius' *Bauhaus Manifesto* radically breaks down the divisions between arts and craft. He hoped: "to achieve, in a new architecture, the unification of all training in art and design."² Gropius wanted to found a school unlike the art academies of his time, which he saw as lulling artists "into a dream of genius...being prepared for the 'profession' of architecture, painting, sculpture or graphic art, without being given the equipment of a real education."³ These artists, in the end, were "confined to a sort of drawing-painting that had no

¹ Walter Gropius, "The Theory and Organization of the Bauhaus," in *Bauhaus, 1919–1928*, ed. Herbert Bayer, Walter Gropius, and Ise Gropius (New York: The Museum of Modern Art, 1938), 2.

² Ibid, 2.

³ Ibid, 2.

relation to the realities of materials, techniques, or economics. A lack of all vital connection with the life of the community led inevitably to barren aesthetic speculation.”⁴ Without a broad understanding of art and craft, these students’ futures were lost. They left learning mediums without an understanding of material or technique, and with no ability to translate their skills into professions. Their skills were lost on society. However, students studying at the Bauhaus would be able to develop theories and functional, reproducible works. Berger is a successful example of the effects of the Bauhaus’ pedagogy; she was able to develop functional fabrics and left the school to become a designer and partner with industry. Gropius writes in his book, *The Scope of Total Architecture*, “Good Architecture should be a projection of life itself and that implies an intimate knowledge of biological, social, technical, and artistic problems.”⁵ We should not assume Gropius is referring only to architecture, but all mediums that encompass creating a space: woodworking, metalworking, lighting, painting, ceramics, and weaving. Gropius says that to understand how to solve problems within current architecture, one must have a deep understanding of one’s surroundings and society at large. Berger’s work demonstrates this type of deep understanding; her works solved problems with contemporary textile furnishings that improved society’s spaces.

The Bauhaus was not just a place for teaching revolutionary ideas, but also a close-knit community of artists and radicals. As Patrick Rössler and Anke Blumm have discussed in their chapter “Soft Skills and Hard Facts” from the book *Bauhaus Bodies*, the Bauhaus served as “a marriage market for modern and independent women and men.”⁶ In addition to meeting her long-time partner Ludwig Hilberseimer, Berger developed a close circle of friends at the school,

⁴ Ibid

⁵ Walter Gropius, “Scope of Total Architecture” (Collier Books, 1937), 18.

⁶ Patrick Rössler and Anke Blumm, “Soft Skills and Hard Facts,” essay, in *Bauhaus Bodies: Gender, Sexuality, and Body Culture in Modernism’s Legendary Art School* (New York: Bloomsbury Visual Arts, n.d.).

including Ise Gropius and Gertrud Arndt. Considering her closeness to members at the school and the alignment of Berger and the Bauhaus' values, it's odd to learn that Berger left the Bauhaus after only a brief time as a student and teacher in the Weaving Workshop. What compelled Berger to part with the Bauhaus and her community, open her own atelier, and begin patenting her work? In part, it was the school's problematic choice to usher its female students into the Weaving Workshop, which lacked structure and whose work was overlooked, but also other things. The book *Bauhaus, 1919-1928*, edited by Walter and Ise Gropius and published after the school's closing, poses the question "WHY is the Bauhaus so important?" and the next line answers: "because it faced the problem of good design for mass production."⁷ This statement clearly expresses a belief that the Bauhaus changed the world through making good, mass-producible designs. However, did it really? Berger's ideas manifested into actual products that were produced on a large scale, whilst the Bauhaus' ideas largely remained theoretical. Even further, through reexamining the Bauhaus school and its policies in relation to Berger, one can see instances of the Bauhaus' revolutionary ideas, when enacted into school policies, actually dampening the success of its artists, like Berger, from achieving them. Berger and her work were revolutionary, and to understand this, we must look past the dominant narrative of the school, and instead closely examine her objects, their use, and her successful linkage of industry and craft as an inventor and patentor.

The piece of fabric from the beginning of this essay is Berger's *Möbelstoff-Doppelgewebe* design, which Berger developed through extensive research and experimentation with material and technique. While you may notice its tatter and fray, what's not obvious to the eye is its durability. Its structure, a particular type of double-weave, is an

⁷Walter Gropius, *Bauhaus, 1919-1928*, ed. Herbert Bayer, Walter Gropius, and Ise Gropius (New York: The Museum of Modern Art, 1938), 3.

invention of Berger's (Figure 1). Her use of two layers of fiber woven simultaneously allowed the work to be incredibly durable and resistant to wear. The fact that there are multiple woven layers is not likely to be noticed, but their impact on furniture in highly-trafficked public spaces would have been evident. These fabrics had a drastically improved ability to withstand heavy use and wear. Another trait likely unnoticed except through having a tactile relationship with the work is its synthetic fiber. The use of synthetic materials for weaving was relatively new for the time and made possible by improvements in industrialization during the 1920-30s. The fiber made this material incredibly strong and resistant to wear and dirt. The durability and stain resistance of the furniture fabric allowed for cleaner public spaces. Though these details are small and likely missed when just glancing at a photo of this work, Berger's designs radically improved the spaces they inhabited. Through the fabrics' utility in their intended environments, their value becomes clear.

Many of Berger's fabrics are in muted colors or not colored at all, but it's the qualities that cannot be seen that make her work radical. When conducting research on Berger's designs for wall coverings, art historian Judith Raum and textile designer Katja Stelz commented that they had to use a needle to push around threads to reveal "deeper layers of weave" that could not be seen.⁸ When Stelz conducted research on Berger's designs, she knew that to understand the fabrics, she had to go through the process of replicating them (Figure 2). This demonstrates their value stems from their techniques and material, and not so much the visual effects. As Stelz says, "Weaving is thinking with your hands. To reproduce a weave, I have to get up close to the fabric."⁹ Stelz describes how when light shines on Berger's wall covering design made of ramie fiber, they appear translucent (Figure 3). The gaps in the weave let light shine onto the wall.

⁸ Nina Wiedermeyer, "In Dialogue with Otti Berger: An Interview with Textile Designer Katja Stelz," *Das Bauhaus-Archiv / Museum für Gestaltung*, December 8, 2025.

⁹ Ibid.

Berger also designed the wall covering's backing, using a shiny, silver material that allowed the light that peaks through the covering to reflect back onto the room. This effect both better illuminated the room and added ambiance to the space. Though the fabrics are not exactly bold or eye-catching, there was certainly more than meets the eye.

Berger's woven works do not focus on the abstraction nor subject matter that was common for Bauhaus weaving circa 1920s. Instead, they focus on functional materials and techniques. "One should ask about its function first," Berger writes in *Stoffe im Raum*, regarding creating a woven work.¹⁰ *Stoffe im Raum* is Berger's theoretical text, written in 1930, where she sets out to redefine the value of weaving. Instead of prescribing it with a pictorial purpose, Berger instead argues that weaving's value lies in its function. Scholar Judith Raum writes of Berger, that her fabrics were "not only functional in the traditional sense of a textile, but were capable of enhancing, insulating, and otherwise adjusting the architectural framework of a space."¹¹ Berger herself describes her aims as the following: "we do not want pictures, we want to achieve the best possible, definitive, living fabric!"¹² By "living," Berger means fabrics that are transformative, something that excels in functioning so well as to appear alive in its transformative effects on a space. She explains what a wall covering should do as follows: "The function of a wall covering is to protect the wall, to insulate heat or cold, perhaps to increase light. Above all, it must appear stretched and hygienic, ideally, easy to wash off."¹³ Note here the lack of attention Berger gives to the work's decorative quality. She is conceptualizing material and technique not in terms of visual aesthetics, but as elements, that with the proper research and experimentation can be properly chosen to fit each fabric's purpose. Berger believed that to use

¹⁰ Berger, Otti, "Stoffe im Raum" 1930, In *Otti Berger: Weaving for Modernist Architecture*, (Hatje Cantz Verlag GmbH, 2024), 17.

¹¹ Judith Raum, *Otti Berger: Weaving for Modernist Architecture*, (Hatje Cantz Verlag GmbH, 2024), 17.

¹² *Ibid*, 34.

¹³ *Ibid*, 35.

the right materials for weaving, one must be considerate of how fibers can aid the function of an object and its effect on a space. She writes: “Not every material is suitable for every structure...material is changed through structure.” By this, she means a single material is not right for every purpose. It's noteworthy that Berger's choices could go against Bauhaus instruction. When told to use more expensive, fine materials by later Bauhaus director Mies Van der Rohe, Berger cites that would be “incommensurate with the idea to design affordable products for a broad public.”¹⁴ The price of a material isn't indicative of its functional quality, nor fitting for objects intended to be affordable, mass-producible goods. The choice of each material depends on what its effect and purpose should be. Berger specifies in her text: “A smooth material reflects light, a rough material absorbs it.” In the case of a wall covering, the use of smooth materials can create a more relaxing setting through lighting the room. A rough material for wall covering would have been used in a different setting, like a concert hall, where the furnishings must aid the sound of performances and absorb light. Unfortunately, Berger's essay, while opening up the doors to new conceptions of weaving, was ignored by the larger Bauhaus community.¹⁵

Let's look at another example of Berger's experimentation with material. Berger invented and patented a design called *künstliche Rosshaar*, a fiber made of synthetic horsehair that was strong and resistant to wear (Figure 4). Here is an example of her fabric. The warp threads, the ones that run vertically across the weave, are a shiny nylon material, and the weft, horizontal threads are a tan color. The nylon material, with its shininess, looks like a “plexiglas” surface that acts to protect the colored threads beneath it.¹⁶ The double layers of weave allow the back

¹⁴ Ibid, 170.

¹⁵ T'ai Smith, “The Haptics of Optics,” *Bauhaus Weaving Theory*, November 1, 2014, 79–110, <https://doi.org/10.5749/minnesota/9780816687237.003.0003>, 81.

¹⁶ T'ai Smith, “Weaving as Invention,” *Bauhaus Weaving Theory*, November 1, 2014, 111–40, <https://doi.org/10.5749/minnesota/9780816687237.003.0004>, 57.

layer, which is white cotton, to be protected from wear. The nylon material makes the fiber flexible enough to bend but not so much that creases form.¹⁷ The protective cover of this fiber allowed it to be an excellent protective surface for covering furniture in heavy use like train interiors. Tai Smith argues that Berger's fabric "sets a boundary" between the user and the space.¹⁸ The furniture covers did not cushion the occupant; it did not encourage the lingering of the user in this heavily trafficked public space. With the end of the Wilhelmine, and the start of the Weimar period in Germany, modernism had struck Germany. Bertold Brecht describes modern city residents as such: "they strive for the greatest possible mobility and are constantly alert, 'as if they had an electric bell going off nonstop inside them.'" ¹⁹ Modern public spaces were no frills, all function. People now traversed spaces, passing through them quickly, requiring spaces and objects that enabled a painless and quick journey, not hindered by comfy cushions easy to sink into and fall asleep in, or lush, ornate surfaces to stare at endlessly. Berger's fabric is incredibly modern in this regard, making fibers perfect for the fast-paced and anonymous spaces of the new, modern world. The textureless, glossy material of the fabric was perfect for the experience of transit and anonymity. It drew no attention to itself, and thus also the passengers. The textile "mirrored" the needs of the space and the user. ²⁰

Berger's fabrics are indicators of the transformation that took place within the Weaving Workshop in the late 20's. This change was marked by the school's move from Weimar to Dessau, Germany. With the physical change in location came a shift in the school's focus, one now dedicated to making industrial goods. That had been the focus before, but much less so; workshops had been given much more freedom to experiment prior to the move to Dessau.

¹⁷ Ibid

¹⁸ Ibid

¹⁹ Bertolt Brecht, "Ozeanflug," essay, in *Gesammelte Werke* (Frankfurt am Main, 1967), 584.

²⁰ Smith, "Weaving as Invention," 57.

Becoming solely focused on functionality and production; the Weaving Workshop gained a reputation as a “laboratory for design.” Sigrid Weltge-Wortmann opens her chapter on the Weaving Workshop in Dessau in her book *Women’s Work* claiming: “the tenet of the Dessau Weaving Workshop was to develop affordable, durable, contemporary textiles for a broad market.”²¹ The workshop had become incredibly structured; there was no more abstract experimentation in color but in technology and material. They are also often cited as inventing the “concept of contemporary textile design.”²² Coursework was rigorous, the weaving students worked from the early morning into the night, understanding the properties of their materials, on weaving technology, analysis, and even, “bookkeeping and calculating wages.”²³ Because she was already interested in utilitarian weaving, Otti Berger was especially well adapted to the workshop’s shift towards function, creating hundreds of “functional fabrics” for modern interiors.²⁴

Despite this shift and the fact that the Weaving Workshop was the most financially successful workshop for the school through their selling of bulk goods and industrial prototypes, the work was regarded as too feminine, too unintellectual and not taken to be a vital part of the school’s manifestations or mission. Bruno Adler, a writer closely connected to the Bauhaus artists, wrote about the school: “paradoxically, while the construction of dwellings, the creation of functional objects and technological processes occupied the foreground, in the those years above all it was the important painters who lent luster to the Bauhaus.”²⁵ Though functional fabrics could be made and sold in bulk, fulfilling the Bauhaus’ mission to merge art and industry, the continued importance of painting at the Bauhaus school demonstrates how they continued to

²¹ Sigrid Wortmann Weltge, *Women’s Work: Textile Art from the Bauhaus* (Chronicle Books, 1993), 97.

²² *Ibid*, 10.

²³ *Ibid*, 92.

²⁴ *Ibid*, 11.

²⁵ Eckhard Neumann, *Bauhaus and Bauhaus People: Personal Opinions and Recollections of Former Bauhaus Members and Their Contemporaries* (New York: Van Nostrand Reinhold, 1993), 25.

produce works that are one-off, ornamental, non-functional commodities. Painting has no practical function; it does not supply us with a place to sit nor illuminate a room, so why was it so important at the school? In addition, many of the great designs of the Bauhaus were handcrafted, time-intensive, and used expensive materials. Though the aims of Gropius were craft and industry-oriented, these turned out to be somewhat of a utopian fantasy. The Bauhaus did not stop valuing high art like painting, nor truly embrace making mass-producible designs. So, considering the Weaving Workshop and Berger's contributions to functional, reproducible designs, why were their objects and theories overlooked by the school? Let's now examine the relationship between Berger, the Weaving Workshop and the Bauhaus.

When Walter Gropius began to advertise the Bauhaus, his admission policy included the line: "any person of good reputation without regard to age or sex...will be admitted, as far as space permits."²⁶ However, Gropius underestimated the number of female applicants that would apply. Instead of allowing female students to choose a workshop, a "woman's department" was established. This gendered department was what became the Weaving Workshop. Working outside this scope was not hospitable.²⁷ Marianne Brandt, known for her metal objects like tea sets and lamps that were featured prominently in publications produced by the Bauhaus, had this to say about her decision to work outside of the Weaving Workshop: "at first I was not exactly welcomed: a woman does not belong in the Metal Workshop was the opinion" (Figure 5). Here lies a gap between the Bauhaus' rhetoric and their actions.

In the Weaving Workshop's early years, there was a lack of structure and general confusion as to what these students should focus on. It was decided students should apply Bauhaus' theories on color and form, created for and used by the Bauhaus painters, to fiber.

²⁶ Weltge-Wortmann, *Women's Work*, 41.

²⁷ Ibid, 42.

When looking at these early woven works created in the Workshop, like Lore Leudesdorff's 1923 wall hanging, these works present the same type of content found in Bauhaus painting: "pictorial abstraction"²⁸ (Figure 6). Leudesdorff's tapestry bears similarities to Bauhaus Master Paul Klee's 1928 painting *Castle and Sun*, both consisting of a series of irregular shapes in a variety of colors (Figure 7). Both could be depicting a building, in Leudesdorff's some shapes are reminiscent of sets of stairs. However, both are too abstract and detached from reality to identify, and it's left up to viewers for interpretation. Klee, Wassily Kandinsky, and Johannes Itten were each Masters at the Bauhaus who taught how to arrange "shapes in an abstract composition" and the importance of Color Theory. Early woven works like Leudesdorff's were ornate, colorful tapestries, created to be hung on walls. Ida Kervious' applique separates colors into a grid-like construction interspersed with triangles and squares of various colors (Figure 8). Tapestries were first drafted on paper, (Figure 9) not at all dissimilar to painting, and then created through manipulating the colors of the warp and weft threads of the loom. There was not the same emphasis on creating functional objects as we see in Berger's work in the Bauhaus' early years, except the rare occasional work like Gunta Stölzl's fabric design for her collaboration with Marcel Breuer on *The African Chair* (Figure 10). Still, with this chair, the weave acts like a tapestry that decoratively wraps around the chair's body, beautifying it but not aiding its function. The chair is brightly colored, and the patterning indicates the early Bauhaus' expressionist interests in figures and folk art. Still, Stölzl's weave serves as an ornamental aid to Breuer's object.

Though beautiful and colorful like their contemporaries' paintings on canvas, this did not mean these woven works were valued in the same way. Bauhaus scholar Anja Baumhoff writes:

²⁸ T'ai Smith, "Pictures Made of Wool," *Bauhaus Weaving Theory*, November 1, 2014, 79–110, <https://doi.org/10.5749/minnesota/9780816687237.003.0003>, 1-39.

“the former Bauhaus student and weaver Anni Albers...realized that her works on paper were categorized as art, but that a similar motif in textile design was suddenly regarded as craft.”²⁹

Woven works following the guidelines set for painting at the Bauhaus were not evaluated as fine art, but decorative handicraft. In contrast, paintings following these teachings supposedly spoke to the complex feelings of the soul. As Johannes Itten, once the Weaving Workshop's Form Master writes in his book *The Elements of Color*, describing the effects of proper color usage: “It is this power of material and chromatic realities to generate unreal vibrations that affords the artist his opportunity to express the ineffable.”³⁰ Clearly, color and form had a near supernatural power in the eyes of Bauhausers, so why did this ability not translate to woven works following the same guidelines? Woven works were not *art* like painting, but *craft*. The two mediums are, of course, different. With one, you paint with a brush and the other you “paint” with the warp and weft of a loom. Even still, if this difference in the act of making subjugated the weavers' work, why had they been instructed to do so in the first place? Walter Gropius wrote in his 1926 text *The Failings of the Workshops* that for the Weaving Workshop, it was “imperative to develop designs” in the way “any textile mill does.”³¹ Clearly, Bauhaus leaders saw the weavers less as artists and more as workers. These actions indicate both a disinterest in the female weaving students' education and also Gropius' mismanaged promise to strip away the biases and boundaries between art and craft, and men and women. Considering the Bauhaus' first proclamation, written by Gropius, lines like “let us create a new guild of craftsmen...together let us conceive and create the new building of the future, which will embrace architecture and

²⁹ Anja Baumhoff, essay, in *The Gendered World of the Bauhaus: The Politics of Power at the Weimar Republic's Premier Art Institute* (Frankfurt a.M: P. Lang, 2001), 478-479.

³⁰ Ibid, 18.

³¹ Weltge-Wortmann, *Women's Work*, 90.

sculpture and painting in one unity and which will rise one day toward heaven,” these promises seem to collapse when anything “feminine” enters the equation.

Form Masters of the Bauhaus like Johannes Itten, Paul Klee, and founder Walter Gropius, didn’t exactly know how to approach this medium. Anni Albers wrote of George Muche, one of the many Weaving Workshop Form Masters, that he “knew nothing about the textile end.”³²

Muche was not only ignorant of weaving but also wrote in his memoir: “I promised myself that I would never in my life with my own hands weave a single thread, tie a single knot, make a single textile design. I have kept my word.”³³ Clearly, it was not just a lack of knowledge for Muche, but hatred. Muche’s comment contradicts the very principles of the school’s founding. The Bauhaus believed Workshop Masters and students should “work side by side,” rejecting the “hierarchies that made conventional academies such authoritarian institutions.”³⁴ For a school founded on democratic principles, these were nowhere to be seen within the Weaving Workshop. While Bauhaus Masters paved the way for modern conceptions of painting and furniture, weaving was disdained and misunderstood. Lead male figures at the Bauhaus were openly dismissive of its artists. Theater Workshop director Oskar Schlemmer wrote, “Where there is wool, there is a woman who weaves, if only to pass the time.”³⁵ Weaving did not have the authority that painting did for men like Schlemmer. In addition, women were dissuaded from joining other workshops by Form Masters. Gerhard Marcks, the Pottery Workshop Master, wrote: “if possible, not to admit women into the Pottery Workshop, both for their sake and for the sake of the workshop.”³⁶ So, while there was an enthusiastic shove of female students into fiber, there was a contempt for the medium.

³² Weltge-Wortmann, *Women’s Work*, 59.

³³ George Muche, *George Muche: Bilder Der Schuld, 1927-1945* (Berlin, DDR: Staatliche Museen, 1985).

³⁴ Shearer West, *The Visual Arts in Germany: 1890-1937 ; Utopia and Despair* (New Brunswick, N.J: Rutgers Univ. Press, 2001), 145.

³⁵ Weltge-Wortmann, *Women’s Work*, 41.

³⁶ Ibid, 42.

We can see how Berger responded to these Bauhaus Masters' comments in her personal scrapbook. On one page, the heads of the lead male figures at the Bauhaus are placed alongside the words *Kunst*, the German word for “art” and *Männerschönheit* for “male beauty” (Figure 11). To Berger, the word *art* is reserved for them. *Art* was abstract, spiritual, and off-limits to the school's female weavers. This explains why Berger chose to carve out a space for herself not as an ‘artist,’ but somewhere between designer, craftsmen and inventor. Unlike Bauhaus artists like Paul Klee and Wassily Kandinsky (Figure 12), Berger distanced herself from the label of “artist,” instead embodying the role of an inventor, due to her focus on functional design.³⁷ Berger defined herself not through a style or the expression of her inner feelings, like Kandinsky did, but through creating works of the utmost practicality.³⁸ When reminiscing about the Bauhaus, Johannes Itten says: “the aim of my instruction in the *Vorkurs* (basic design course) was education to form the creative individual. This new method became famous throughout the world.”³⁹ Unlike a traditional ‘artist’ like Itten, Berger did not pursue fame for her work, just authorship. She also did not create “specific commodities,” like paintings, which were individual one-off works that would end up in the hands of collectors. Instead, as a “corporate author,” she sold the “reproduction rights” to her work, allowing her designs to proliferate while retaining credit for them.⁴⁰ With her patents, Berger's designs were found in trains, automobiles, and other public and private spaces.⁴¹ She was also the only Bauhaus weaver to do so. Since commodity artworks were not made to be reproduced, they fundamentally could not reach the masses to the same extent Berger's reproducible designs could.

³⁷ T'ai Smith, “Weaving as Invention,” *Bauhaus Weaving Theory*, November 1, 2014, 111–40, <https://doi.org/10.5749/minnesota/9780816687237.003.0004>, 121.

³⁸ For more on Kandinsky's painting philosophy, see *From Concerning the Spiritual in Art*.

³⁹ Eckhard Neumann, *Bauhaus and Bauhaus People*, 21.

⁴⁰ Smith, “Weaving as Invention,” 113.

⁴¹ Raum, *Otti Berger: Weaving for Modernist Architecture*, (Hatje Cantz Verlag GmbH, 2024).

Despite being an artist in a medium that historically pushed for anonymity, especially among women, Berger fought for authorship over her work. There was also the additional hurdle that according to Bauhaus policy, all work created at the school was legally their property. This meant the Bauhaus had near total control over all aspects of artists' work. In Bauhaus publications like *Die Arbeit der Bauhaus-Werkstätten* and *Katalog der Muster*, student work is reproduced without the artists' names (Figure 5). By stripping artists of authorship over their work and labeling them as 'Bauhaus products,' they became the creations of the school, in the same way that factory-made goods are seen as the products of a company, not its workers. In emphasizing the parallels to mass-production operations, the Bauhaus presented itself as a revolutionary entity that produced goods for the masses. As said earlier, Gropius emphasized that the Weaving Workshop should "develop designs" in the way "any textile mill does," which implies that he believes these artists to be laborers, anonymous factory workers working away at the designs of others.⁴² He assumes that these artists are interchangeable and dispensable, which was certainly not the case. This was clearly a concern for Berger.

While at the school, Berger was invited to participate in a 1932 show, *The Creative Work of Women*, and petitioned the school for "the loan of her piano cover" woven for Paul Klee, which, in her request, she titles her work: "apprenticeship projects otti berger, bauhaus dessau."⁴³ The language of the title both implies a subordinate relationship and adopts the language of the Bauhaus.⁴⁴ Through labeling herself as an "apprentice," she devalues her own role in the work's creation, attributing the work's design to the guidance of the Bauhaus. She also wrote the request in the lowercase alphabet designed by Herbert Bayer, which was used by "everyone at the

⁴² Weltge-Wortmann, *Women's Work*, 90.

⁴³ Ibid, 95.

⁴⁴ Ibid, 95.

Bauhaus.”⁴⁵ The carefully crafted request demonstrates the lengths students had to go to convince Bauhaus masters to allow them to use their own designs. Berger’s request was permitted because she was seen as skilled; however, there was uncertainty whether she would always be granted these requests.⁴⁶ As Magdalena Droste writes in her article *The Bauhaus Object between Authorship and Anonymity*, Marcel Breuer also attempted to regain authorship over his designs for tubular steel furniture, which he made while at the Bauhaus (Figure 13).⁴⁷ Walter Gropius expected that the profits from these designs would benefit the school; however, Breuer argued that his works were “his private possessions.”⁴⁸ Since Breuer was a Junior Master at the school, Gropius sanctioned these actions in order to retain him at the school. Breuer, in contrast to Berger and the weaving artists at the Bauhaus, was given a much greater ability to do so.

However, in 1933, Berger became more assertive about authorship over her own work. She wrote in a letter to Sigfried Gideon: “there is no way I will continue to remain anonymous.”⁴⁹ Both the subjugated status of weaving at the Bauhaus and the school’s stripping of authorship contributed to Berger’s decision to leave the Bauhaus. She had thought about leaving the Bauhaus prior to 1932 but stayed longer to ensure there was a proper teacher to replace her within the Weaving Workshop. She wrote in a 1931 letter: “I may be asked to remain here [the Bauhaus] for another quarter of the year, as the Weaving Workshop is still without new leadership. The situation is still very unclear, as the atmosphere at the Bauhaus has always been. I, however, have a clear program in mind. That alone makes it impossible to implement at the

⁴⁵ Ibid, 95.

⁴⁶ Ibid, 95.

⁴⁷ Droste, Magdalena. “The Bauhaus Object between Authorship and Anonymity.” In *Bauhaus Construct: Fashioning Identity, Discourse and Modernism*, (Routledge, 2009), 211.

⁴⁸ Ibid, 211.

⁴⁹ Otti Berger to Sigfried Gideon, November 21, 1933, in Otti Berger: Weaving for Modernist Architecture, ed. Judith Raum (Berlin: Hatje Cantz, 2024), 26.

Bauhaus.”⁵⁰ Considering the Bauhaus’ lack of coherent pedagogy for the Weaving Workshop, it is no wonder that Berger began to consider other outlets for her designs, like the patent. She began consulting with an attorney about patenting her fabrics shortly before leaving the school.⁵¹ 1933, the year she parted with the Bauhaus, she first registered to patent her *Möbelstoff-Doppelgewebe* design, a double-woven fabric intended for furniture that used synthetic horsehair (Figures 14 and 15).⁵² When she left the school, she “requested that they overturn a provision of the contract, which had stated –as per usual Bauhaus policy– that all work she developed while in tenure at the school was the legal property of Bauhaus GmbH.”⁵³ It was important to her that her inventions were accredited to her so that she could legally sell them to industrial companies.

Berger’s fears of not receiving proper credit for her work also were due to the nature of her designs. Her fabric focused on functionality rather than visual style, meaning her work could outwardly appear “rather unremarkable.”⁵⁴ A fabric sample of Berger’s *Möbelstoff-Doppelgewebe*, for instance, with its muted blue threads woven uniformly seems like a simple construction (Figure 1). However, it is deceptively complex. The fabric’s double-weave technique created a very durable, thick fabric. The fabric’s synthetic materials made the upholstered surfaces “remarkably strong” and “water and tear resistant.”⁵⁵ The fabric’s absence of style, however, meant it lacked any obvious indications of Berger’s authorship, which explains her decision to patent it. Doing so allowed it to be “fortified by the language of the patent text.”⁵⁶

⁵⁰ Otti Berger to Adolf Loos, November 1931, in Otti Berger: Weaving for Modernist Architecture, ed. Judith Raum (Berlin: Hatje Cantz, 2024), 19.

⁵¹ Raum, *Otti Berger*, 20.

⁵² Smith, “Weaving as Invention,” 119.

⁵³ Ibid, 119.

⁵⁴ Smith. “The Identity of Design as Intellectual Property.” In *Bauhaus Construct: Fashioning Identity, Discourse and Modernism*, (Routledge, 2009), 236.

⁵⁵ Raum, *Otti Berger*, 121-122.

⁵⁶ Smith. “The Identity of Design as Intellectual Property.” In *Bauhaus Construct*, 236-237.

Using a legal framework, she lays out her design's unique qualities, citing how the double-woven structure gave it "strength and durability."⁵⁷ Her patent application, and its success, allowed her to demonstrate the design's complex construction and claim credit for both the design and research she had done with materials at the Bauhaus. Attaining the patent, her *Möbelstoff-Doppelgewebe* was legally labelled a "technical innovation" of Berger's.⁵⁸

When establishing her own company *Otti Berger Atelier für Textilien* (Studio for Textiles) in 1932, Berger intentionally distanced herself from labels of handweaving, thereby dispelling any association with handicraft. *Why?* The derogatory implications of this word for weaving. Walter Gropius writes in his 1919 Bauhaus Manifesto: "The Bauhaus strives to reunite arts and crafts—sculpture, painting, applied art, and handicrafts—as the permanent elements of a new architecture." Note here the use of the term *handicraft*. The word refers to weaving, but using *handicraft* as a descriptor implies two things. Considering the definition: "a particular skill of making decorative objects by hand," Gropius' phrase demonstrates the belief that weaving at the Bauhaus is entirely done by hand, and not on a loom, implying that the medium is disconnected from industry and technology. The phrase also implies that the medium serves a decorative purpose, and not a functional one. "Fabrics in the home are much more than a 'decoration,' Berger once wrote, and it was clear she had no intention to do anything decorative. The distancing from the *handicraft* label allowed Berger to be taken more seriously as a textile designer. Berger's decision to patent her work translates Bauhaus rhetoric into industrial action, enabling her to sell her designs to companies including *Sächsische Rosshaarweberei Schriever & Co* and *Wohnbedarf AG*.

⁵⁷ Smith, "The Identity of Design as Intellectual Property," 237.

⁵⁸ Ibid, 236.

But what happens to the value of Berger's fabrics when they stop being in use? What happens when the fabrics are no longer on furniture and now look like tattered scraps sitting in the drawers of museums' collections? Most of Berger's objects, at least the ones that survived, are stored and catalogued away, let out for the occasional exhibition which comes far and few between. Though Berger has been long gone from this world, her objects can still hold value in their own right. To experience these works now in the 21st century can actually reveal a new value. At work in these objects, these pieces of furniture and wall coverings are *thing power*. Jane Bennett coined this phrase in her book *Vibrant Matter*. She describes it as the ability for objects to hold value outside their connection to human life and culture. When Judith Raum, art historian, artist, and Otti Berger scholar, created an installation exhibit about the functional fabrics made at the Bauhaus, she had this to say:

Upon my first contact with the material it was samples of functional fabrics at the Bauhaus Archiv in Berlin. I was intrigued by their outstanding material quality, something that did not at all manifest itself in two-dimensional illustrations but only when you held these fabrics in your own hand and were able to feel their rigidity, softness, their warm or cold character...How important it was to be able to lift and turn the fabric...the functional fabrics: upholstery fabric, curtain fabric, wall spanning fabric seem to me like bundles of condensed energy.⁵⁹

The use of the phrase "bundles of condensed energy" by Raum is especially interesting, especially when recalling Jane Bennett's definition of *thing power*: "the curious ability of

⁵⁹ Judith Raum, "Opening Celebration for "The Bauhaus and Harvard" with Judith Raum" (lecture, Harvard Art Museums, Massachusetts, February 7, 2019).

inanimate things to animate, to act, to produce.” Raum seems to describe the kinetic presence of the fabrics that exists outside the context of Berger perfectly. This effect, instead, comes from the tactile relationship to the fiber. This action is most present in the fabric’s functional features, such as its ability to bend, stretch, and adjust itself to the user’s needs. Its responses to engagement are like those of something alive. These fabrics in use are kinetic.

Since we may not have immediate access to Berger’s work in museums and her fabrics no longer furnish public spaces, how should we as 21st century people understand the value of Berger’s work if we cannot see it firsthand? Well, photographs. Though Judith Raum argues that photographs strip Berger’s work of its qualities, Berger would not entirely agree. Photography as an artistic medium was debated almost immediately following its invention. At the Bauhaus, especially so. For the first ten years of the Bauhaus being open, there was no photography workshop. It only became so in 1929, two years after Otti Berger arrived at the school. Well-known and highly influential Bauhaus photographer László Moholy-Nagy describes the medium as “purely optical.” If we look to lines from *Stoffe im Raum* like “a fabric is not only an optical object...most important in cloth is its tactility” Berger specifically steers readers away from conceptualizing fiber only optically.⁶⁰ Considering this assertion, why did Berger, who writes extensively of fiber’s importance beyond just the optical, embrace photography as a significant way of highlighting the value of weaving? Well, the optical and the tactile collide in Berger’s photographs. As T’ai Smith writes in her chapter *The Haptics of Optics* in the book *Bauhaus Weaving Theory*, “Photography acted as the lens through which texture could (literally) be seen, and through which weaving at the Bauhaus came to be recognized and sold.”⁶¹ So, unexpectedly, photography was a means in which Berger could visualize the textural qualities of

⁶⁰ Berger, Otti, “Stoffe im Raum,” 1930, in Otti Berger: Weaving for Modernist Architecture, ed. Judith Raum (Berlin: Hatje Cantz, 2024), 34.

⁶¹ T’ai Smith, “The Haptics of Optics,” 109.

weaving. In the 1920's and 1930's, the modern world was just beginning. Images proliferated everywhere in advertisements, films, and magazines. Berger's text appeared in the Czech journal *ReD* alongside Bauhaus textiles. Using photography, Berger's designs and ideas could reach a wider group of people. In *Meaningful Things and Appropriate Myths*, Henry Glassie makes the point that objects reach a broader group of the population because a smaller percentage of the world is literate.⁶² Objects "offer the possibility of a way to understand the mind of the great majority of nonliterate people, past and present, who remain otherwise inaccessible."⁶³ So, photographs of her work made her ideas more accessible. Berger highlights her points both visually, through photographs, and verbally, through her texts. Berger was entrepreneurial; she knew how to attract and convince people of functional fabrics' value. Her photographs operate in the same sense that product advertisements would, convincing readers of the merits of these inventions and how they could improve their everyday lives.

Walter Gropius once remarked "Only by the strength of his imagination can he project his ideas so that they will last beyond his lifetime. I have observed that it takes at least a generation before a new idea can be diffused safely." Though Berger's designs are no longer in use within spaces, her ideas have certainly had a lasting effect. When Amtrak decided it was time to redo their worn-out train interiors, they knew they wanted something that conveyed "comfort and style." The renovation process included them testing out "20 prototypes for durability and arriving at a subtly patterned blue nylon carpet." Amtrak spokesperson Alison Simon said about the renovation: "Even though it looks like we haven't changed them in years, I guarantee you it's been changed in the last year." Both comments are indicative that current industrial design still

⁶² Henry Glassie, "Meaningful Things and Appropriate Myths: The Artifacts Place in American Studies," essay, in *Prospects: An Annual of American Cultural Studies* (New York: Burt Franklin, 1977), 29-30.

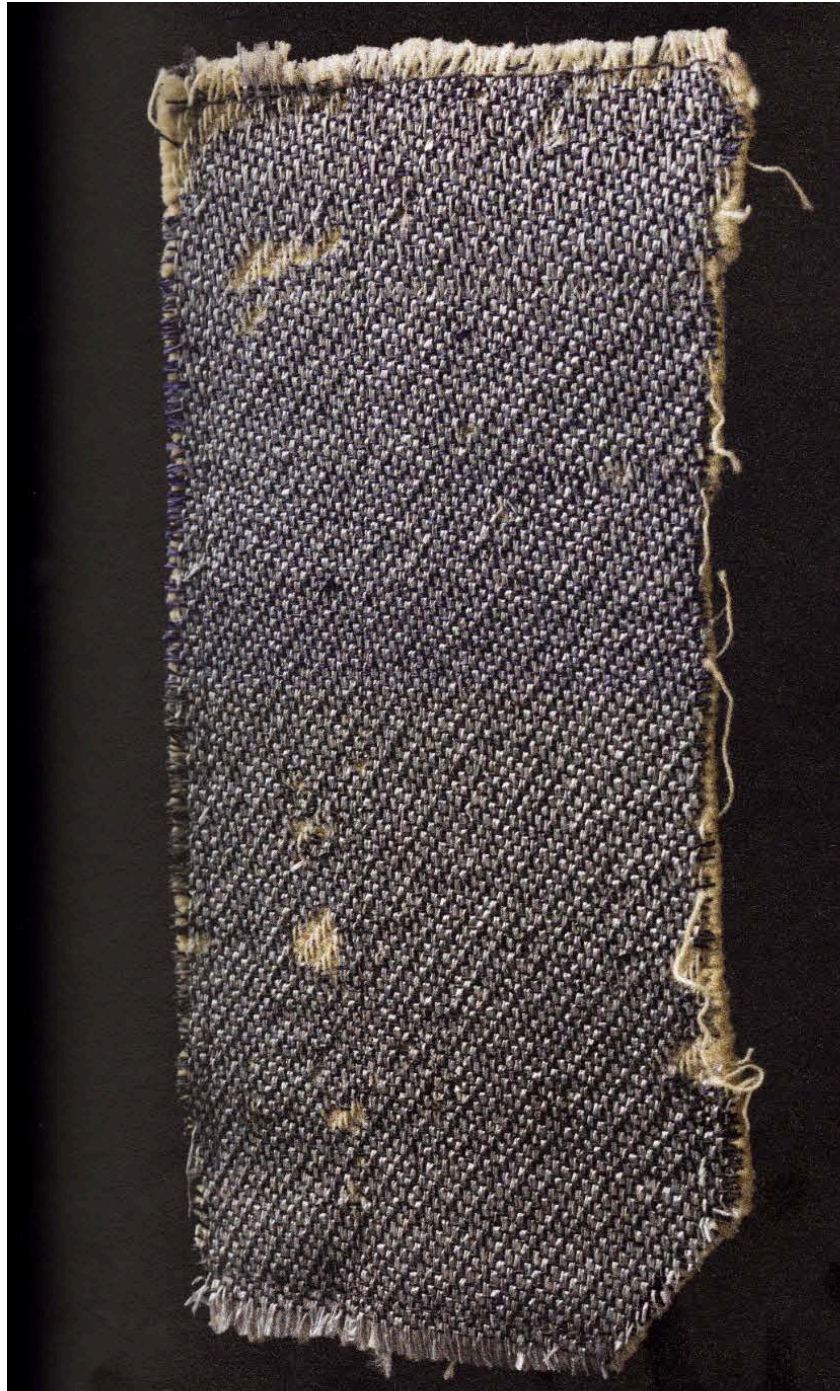
⁶³ Jules David Prown, "Mind in Matter: An Introduction to Material Culture Theory and Method," *Winterthur Portfolio* 17, no. 1 (1982): 1-19, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/1180761>.

draws on the principles and strategies developed by designers like Berger. Like Berger, Amtrak puts a high value on developing prototypes and experimenting with the durability and functionality of their designs so they could be put into mass use. Amtrak's choice to use subtle colors and patterns, harkens back to Berger's inconspicuous fabrics for public spaces that don't draw attention to themselves or the viewer. The similarity between Amtrak and Berger's choices reflect that even though Berger's designs are not still in use, her revolutionary ideas surrounding functional design, prototyping and experimenting have had a lasting influence on the current design world.

In conclusion, while the Bauhaus preached utopian ideas about function and industrial goods, Berger thought with her hands. The Bauhaus saw itself as an entity of artists operating collaboratively, but they neglected to give their artists authorship, and in Berger's case, respect. If one is to look beyond just the surface level history of the Bauhaus, which I admit is harder than you'd think, you will find stories like that of Otti Berger. Berger's fabrics and authorship complicate the Bauhaus' history. It complicates the linear narrative of the school, but also enhances it. Despite the fact that Berger's actions and work were not fully understood or supported by the school, she represents a Bauhaus artist putting the school's rhetoric into action. To return the Bauhaus its label as the "school that merged art and craft" and a "revolutionary group of artists," one must look to the artists like Berger who truly made these ideas manifest.

FIGURES

Figure 1.



Berger, Otti, *Sample for Wall Covering*, cellulose-based ribbon, 1933, Museum für Gestaltung Zürich, In *Otti Berger: Weaving for Modernist Architecture*, by Judith Raum.

Figure 2.



Photo of the exhibition *Otti Berger. Weaving for Modernist Architecture*, An installation by Judith Raum at the Bauhaus-Archiv Museum für Gestaltung, March 15 - August 24, 2024. Wall covering made by Katja Stelz.

Figure 3.



Berger, Otti, *White Ramie Ribbon Wall Covering*, 1932-34. Photo by Ernst Nipkow. In *Otti Berger: Weaving for Modernist Architecture*, by Judith Raum.

Figure 4.



Berger, Otti, *Sample for Upholstery Fabric*, ribbed artificial horsehair double weave, 1932-34, Bauhaus Archiv. In *Otti Berger: Weaving for Modernist Architecture*, by Judith Raum.

Figure 5.



Brandt, Marianne, *Tea Infuser (MT 49)*, silver and ebony, 1924, Bauhaus Kooperation. Photo taken by the *Bauhaus Katalog der Muster*, Brandt is uncredited.

Figure 6.



Leudesdorff, Lore, *Wall Hanging*, wool, 1923, Bauhaus-Archiv / Museum Für Gestaltung, Berlin.

Figure 7



Klee, Paul, *Castle and Sun*, paint on canvas, 1928.

Figure 8.



Kerkovius, Ida, *Wall Hanging*, felt, 1921, Taken from Sigrid Weltge-Wortmann's Book *Women's Work: Textile Art from the Bauhaus*.

Figure 9.



Itten, Johannes, *Designs for rugs*, graph paper, early 1920s. Taken from Sigrid Weltge-Wortmann's Book *Women's Work: Textile Art from the Bauhaus*.

Figure 10.



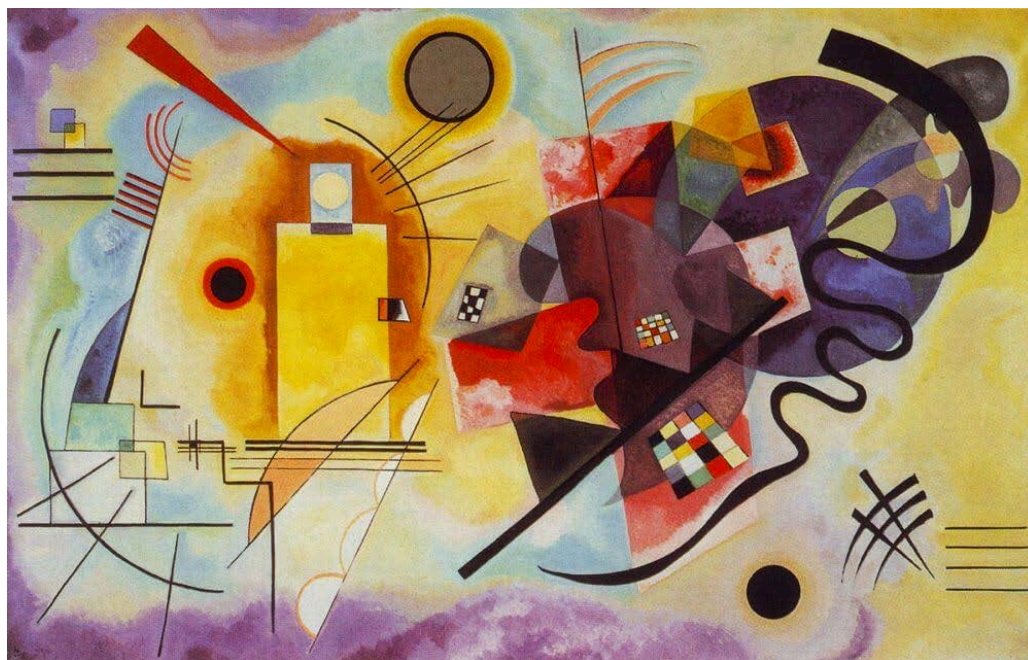
Marcel Breuer and Gunta Stölzl, *African Chair*, wood and wool, 1921, Bauhaus-Archiv / Museum für Gestaltung, Berlin.

Figure 11.



Berger, Otti. *Bauhaus Scrapbook*, 1898-1944. Photographs and color. Art Institute of Chicago Archives.

Figure 12.



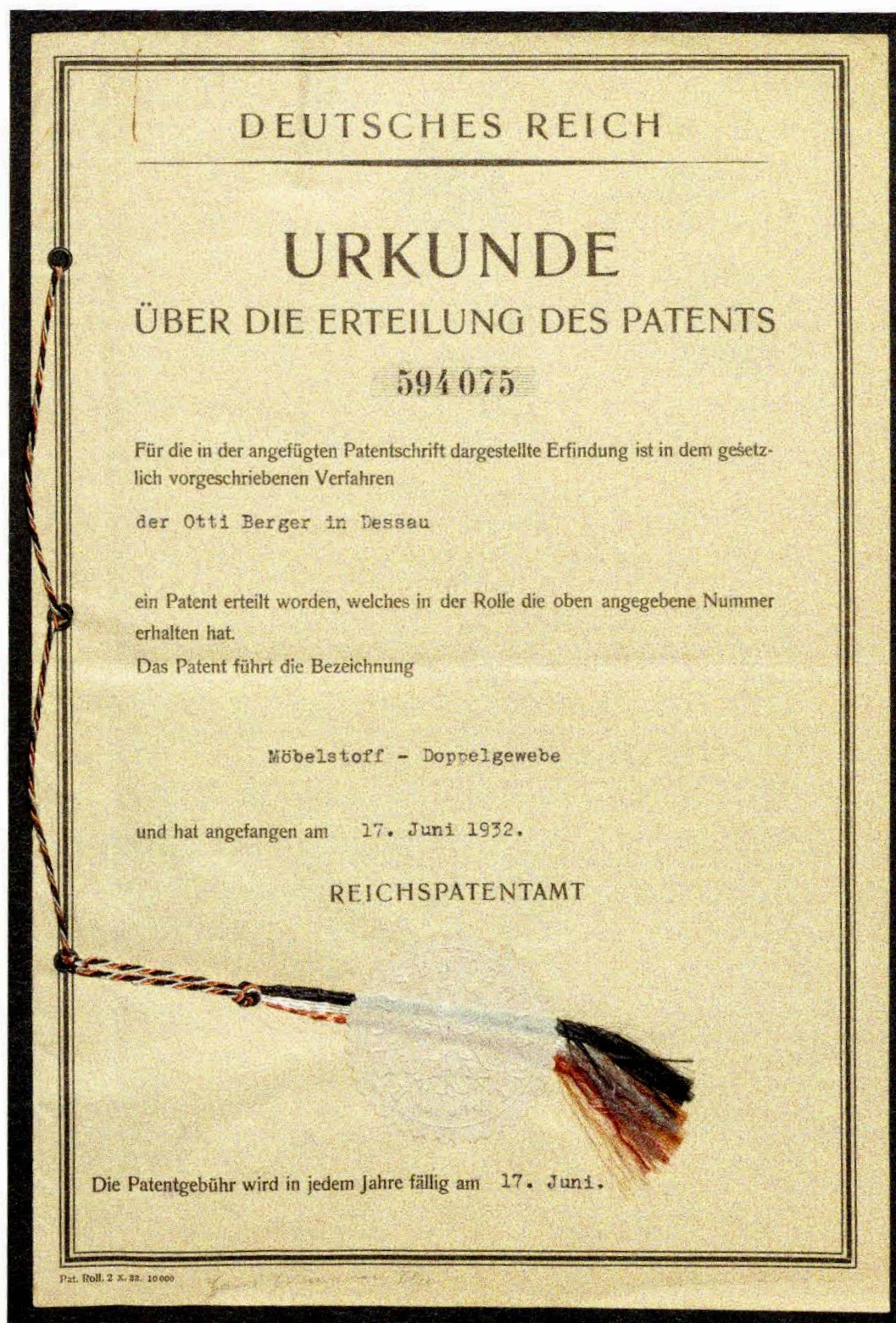
Kandinsky, Wassily, *Yellow-Red-Blue*, oil on canvas, 1925, Georges Pompidou Center, Paris, France.

Figure 13.



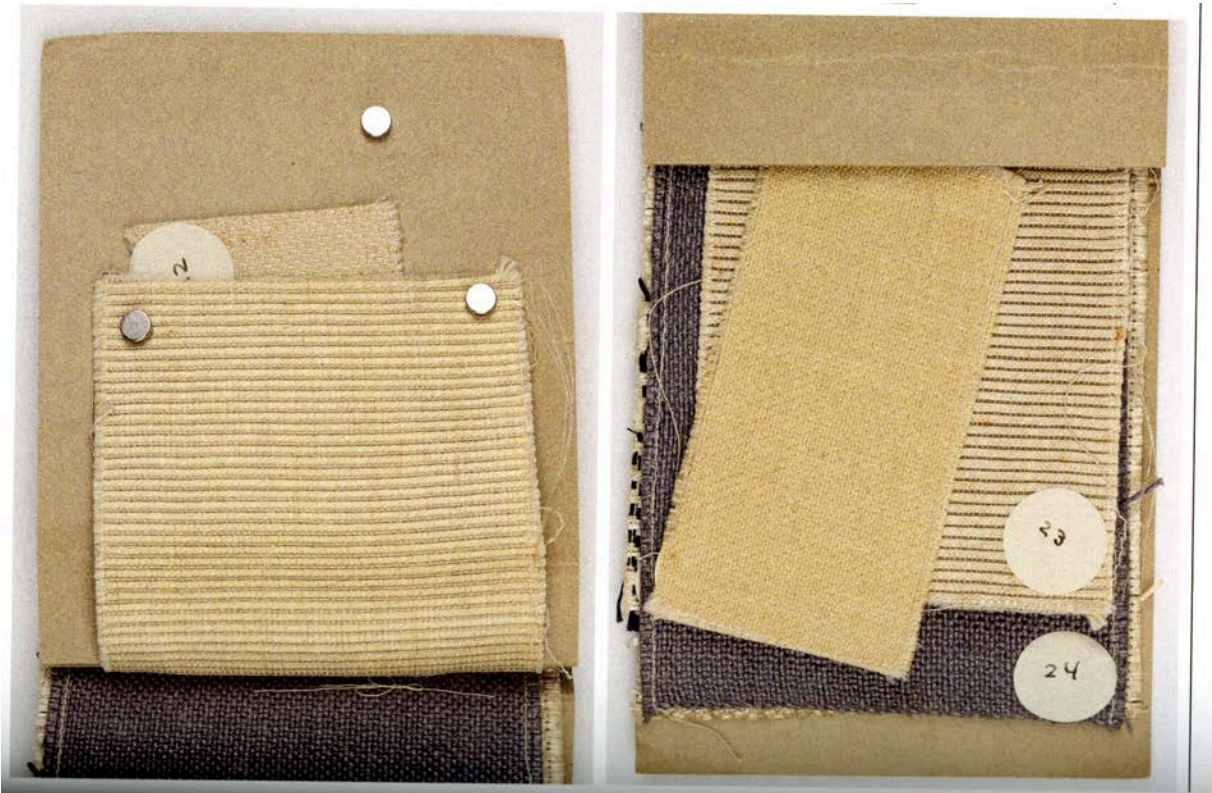
Breuer, Marcel, *Chair (Model B33)*, tubular steel and steel thread, 1927-28, Museum of Modern Art, New York.

Figure 14.



Berger, Otti, Möbelstoff-Doppelgewebe Patent Certificate, 1932, German Reich Patent Office.

Figure 15.



Berger, Otti, *Möbelstoff-Doppelgewebe Sample Book*, 1932-34. In *Otti Berger: Weaving for Modernist Architecture*, by Judith Raum.

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